

Reflecting on Creative Nonfiction

Writing a personal narrative is not a one-way street. The writer shapes memory into story, but the act of writing also shapes the writer. After drafting, after receiving feedback, after revising, the writer must take one final step: reflection. Reflection is not simply looking back. It is looking inward. It asks: Why did I make these choices? How did my memory and identity shape this narrative? How has my voice grown through this process? These questions transform a writing assignment into a deeper understanding of oneself as a writer.

This reading material guides writers through reflecting on how personal memory, identity, and experience influence narrative choices and voice. It also explains how to assess one's evolving voice by reviewing early drafts, peer feedback, and journal entries.

Part 1: How Memory, Identity, and Experience Influence Narrative Choices

Every choice a writer makes – what to include, what to omit, what to emphasize, what tone to take – is shaped by who they are. Memory, identity, and experience are not separate from the writing process. They are the writing process.

Memory: The Raw Material

Aspect of Memory	How It Influences Narrative Choices
What you remember	Determines which events make it into the narrative
What you have forgotten	Forces you to decide whether to acknowledge gaps, reconstruct, or omit

Aspect of Memory

How It Influences Narrative Choices

How you remember (vivid vs. vague)

Influences whether you write in scene (vivid) or summary (vague)

The emotional charge of a memory

Determines the tone (nostalgic, painful, humorous, angry)

The age at which the memory formed

Influences vocabulary and perspective (child narrator vs. adult reflecting)

Reflection question: Which memories did you choose to include? Which did you leave out? Why?

Identity: The Lens

Aspect of Identity

How It Influences Narrative Choices

Age and generation

Shapes perspective on past events (e.g., writing as a teenager vs. looking back as an adult)

Culture and community

Influences what is considered private, shameful, sacred, or humorous

Values and beliefs

Determines what you see as right, wrong, significant, or trivial

Relationships to others (daughter, friend, athlete, immigrant)

Shapes how you portray yourself and others in the narrative

Gender and sexuality

Affects what experiences are centered and how vulnerability is expressed

Reflection question: How does who you are now change how you tell a story from years ago?

Experience: The Accumulated Wisdom

Aspect of Experience	How It Influences Narrative Choices
Past successes and failures as a writer	Affects confidence, risk-taking, and willingness to experiment with structure
Life experiences beyond school	Provides material, perspective, and emotional depth
Reading history (books, essays, articles you have read)	Shapes your sense of what "good writing" sounds like and what is possible
Previous feedback received	Influences what you worry about (e.g., "My last teacher said I summarized too much")
Emotional wounds or joys	Determines what feels too painful to write and what feels essential

Reflection question: What have you read or experienced that taught you something about telling a true story?

Part 2: Assessing One's Evolving Voice

Voice is not fixed. It develops over time, across drafts, across pieces. Assessing one's evolving voice means looking at early drafts, peer feedback, and journal entries to see how the voice has changed – and whether it has become more authentic and consistent.

What to Review

Artifact	What It Reveals About Voice
Early drafts	Shows your initial, unpolished voice – often raw, clichéd, or imitative

Artifact	What It Reveals About Voice
Revised drafts	Shows how your voice matured through revision – more confident, more specific, more you
Peer feedback	Reveals how others hear your voice – what they found authentic or confusing
Journal entries (if kept)	Captures your raw, private voice – often more honest than public writing
Teacher comments	Provides expert guidance on what is working and what needs development

Sample Comparison: Early Draft vs. Final Draft Voice

Feature	Early Draft Voice	Final Draft Voice	What Changed
Opening sentence	"I remember the day my grandmother left."	"The suitcase sat by the door for three hours before she touched it."	Became specific and concrete; showed instead of told
Sentence length	All medium-length, correct but flat	Mix of short (urgency) and long (reflection)	Experimented with pacing
Use of dialogue	None, only summary	Three lines of dialogue that reveal character	Gained confidence in reconstructing speech
Reflection	At the end: "This taught me to appreciate family."	Scattered throughout: images of the suitcase recur	Moved from telling to showing meaning
Tone	Earnest and sentimental	Wry and tender (more complex)	Moved away from cliché toward honest complexity

Questions for Assessing Voice

Question	What It Assesses
Does my opening paragraph sound different from my closing paragraph?	Growth and confidence over the course of writing
Did I borrow phrases or styles from other writers? When did I stop?	Movement from imitation to originality
What did peers say about my voice? Did multiple readers notice the same thing?	Consistency and clarity of voice
Which sentences feel most like me? What do they have in common?	Authenticity and patterns in your authentic voice
How has my voice changed from the first draft to the final draft?	Evolution and development
Where did I take a risk (fragment, white space, non-linear structure)? Did it work?	Willingness to experiment and the result

Signs of a Developing Voice

Sign	What It Means
You cut clichés and replaced them with specific, original details	Your voice is becoming more authentic
You stopped trying to sound "literary" and started sounding like yourself	You are moving away from imitation
You can identify which passages feel false or borrowed	You have developed critical self-awareness

Sign

Readers say they feel like they know you after reading your work

You take risks (fragments, white space, non-linear chronology) that work

Your reflection is integrated, not just a moral tacked on at the end

What It Means

Your voice is consistent and distinctive

You have confidence in your voice

You understand how to show meaning, not just state it

Part 3: A Guided Reflection Exercise

After completing your creative nonfiction piece, write a journal entry (1-2 pages) responding to the prompts below. Be specific. Refer to actual sentences from your drafts.

Part A: Memory and Narrative Choices

What is the central memory at the heart of your narrative?

What details from that memory did you include? What did you leave out? Why?

Where did you acknowledge a gap in your memory? How did you handle it (e.g., "I think," "Perhaps," reconstruction)?

Part B: Identity and Voice

What aspect of your identity (age, culture, family role, values, etc.) most shaped this narrative? Explain how.

If someone who knew you read this anonymously, would they recognize your voice? What specific features of your voice (diction, tone, humor, etc.) would give you away?

Part C: Assessing Your Evolving Voice

Look at your first draft. Find one sentence that feels borrowed or clichéd. Write it here.

Look at your final draft. Find the sentence that replaced it. Write it here. What changed?

What did peer feedback teach you about how your voice comes across? Give one specific example of feedback you received and how you responded to it.

What would you do differently next time to make your voice even more authentic?

Part 4: Sample Reflection (Annotated)

Below is a sample student reflection with annotations showing how it addresses memory, identity, and voice.

Sample Reflection:

Looking back at my first draft of "The Last Dinner," I realize I was trying too hard to sound like a "real writer." My opening sentence was: "The evening was filled with a profound sense of melancholy." That is not how I talk. That is not how I think. I borrowed that sentence from a novel I read last year.

In my final draft, I changed it to: "No one touched the roast chicken."

That sentence is mine. It came from my actual memory – the uneaten food, the silence, the way my mother kept looking at the clock. My identity as the oldest daughter shaped everything about this piece. I noticed everything. I remembered the details because I was the one who cleared the plates. My voice became authentic when I stopped trying to sound profound and just described what I saw.

My peer feedback said the first draft felt "distant" and "like a school essay." The same peer said the final draft made her "feel like she was at the table." That difference – distance vs. presence – is the difference between imitative voice and authentic voice.

Annotations:

Sentence from Sample	What It Demonstrates
"I was trying too hard to sound like a 'real writer.'"	Self-awareness about borrowed voice
"No one touched the roast chicken."	Specific, authentic, concrete detail
"My identity as the oldest daughter..."	Explicit connection between identity and narrative choices
"My voice became authentic when I stopped trying to sound profound..."	Insight into the conditions for authentic voice

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Reflection	The process of looking back on one's own writing to understand choices and growth
Evolving voice	The way a writer's voice changes and matures over time and across drafts
Self-assessment	Evaluating one's own work to identify strengths, weaknesses, and areas for growth
Authenticity	The quality of a voice that feels genuine, not borrowed or performative
Journal entry	A private, informal writing space for reflection, experimentation, and self-discovery
Imitative voice	A voice that sounds like another writer; a necessary stage before finding one's own

Review Questions

1. Explain how personal memory influences narrative choices in creative nonfiction. Provide one specific example of a choice a writer might make based on what they remember or have forgotten.
2. Explain how identity influences narrative choices. Choose one aspect of identity (age, culture, values, family role, gender) and describe how it might shape the way a writer tells a story.
3. List three artifacts a writer should review when assessing their evolving voice (e.g., early drafts). For each artifact, state what it reveals about voice.
4. What are three signs that a writer's voice is developing and becoming more authentic?
5. Look at the sample reflection in Part 4. Identify two specific sentences that show self-awareness about voice. Explain why each sentence demonstrates self-awareness.
6. What is the difference between an imitative voice and an authentic voice? Provide an example of each (either from your own writing or imagined).
7. Reflection journal prompt (to be completed after finishing your creative nonfiction piece): Write a 1-2 paragraph response answering two of the following questions:
 - Looking at my early draft and my final draft, how has my voice changed?
 - What memory did I include that felt most vulnerable to share? Why?
 - What part of my identity most shaped this narrative?
 - What did peer feedback teach me about how my voice comes across?
 - What would I do differently next time to make my voice even more authentic?